

Acne & Boils

Acne and boils are the result of local infection, hormonal imbalance, or internal toxicity, which cause inflammation of the hair follicles and, with acne, sebaceous glands. They should be treated on the surface of the skin and internally.

Acne generally occurs during the teenage years and results in whiteheads, pustules, and cysts, usually on the face and back.

Boils are large, pus-filled areas of skin. They either disperse or burst in a week. As boils are often the body's way of expelling toxins, recurrent boils may indicate a weakened immune system. They can also suggest diabetes or a deep-seated bacterial infection.

Herbs such as tea tree and garlic are antiseptic and antibiotic. Calendula and comfrey promote healing, and comfrey helps to mend scarring.

Self-help

Increase intake of vitamin C and garlic.

❗ **General cautions** Do not squeeze or burst boils or acne pimples as the infection may spread. Seek professional advice for recurrent boils.

External Remedies

Herbs Tea tree (*Melaleuca alternifolia*, p. 112), clove (*Eugenia caryophyllata*, p. 97), garlic (*Allium sativum*, p. 59)

Remedy Dab 1 drop of neat tea tree or clove essential oil onto the pus-filled head of a boil or pimple twice a day. Alternatively, cut a clove of garlic in half and rub over the area twice a day.

Herb Calendula (*Calendula officinalis*, p. 73)

Remedy Apply ointment or cream, or dab undiluted tincture onto the pus-filled area twice a day.

Herb Comfrey (*Symphytum officinale*, p. 138)

Remedy Apply comfrey ointment or cream to the pus-filled area twice a day.

Caution Do not use comfrey on broken skin.

Herb Lemon (*Citrus limon*, p. 82)

Remedy Dab pure lemon juice onto the pus-filled area, or dilute 1 tsp of lemon juice with 1 tbsp of water and use as a skin wash twice a day.

Herbs Slippery elm (*Ulmus rubra*, p. 145), calendula (*Calendula officinalis*, p. 73), myrrh (*Commiphora molmol*, p. 85), echinacea (*Echinacea* spp., p. 92)

Remedy Mix 1 level tsp of slippery elm powder with sufficient calendula, myrrh, or echinacea tincture to make a thick, smooth paste. Place on and around the boil, and bandage securely. Remove after 1–2 hours.

Note This remedy is especially useful for drawing painful boils and splinters.

Internal Remedies

Herbs Dandelion (*Taraxacum officinale*, p. 141), burdock (*Arctium lappa*, p. 65)

Remedy Make a decoction using 5 g of burdock root and 10 g of dandelion root with 3 cups (750 ml) of water. Divide into 3 doses and drink during the day.

Herb Echinacea (*Echinacea* spp., p. 92)

Remedy Take echinacea tablets or capsules, or make a decoction of 10 g of root to 3 cups (750 ml) of water and drink during the day.

Digestive Disorders



Ginger
Zingiber officinale

Everyone falls prey to certain digestive problems and, for those with weak or unsettled digestion, life can be miserable. Poor digestive health usually results from insufficient digestive secretions, infections (such as gastroenteritis), disordered gut bacteria, stress, and anxiety. Herbal medicines can improve the complex functioning of the digestive system, helping to relieve acidity, nausea, and bloating. Eating simple, wholesome food can be beneficial, but it is difficult to generalize about diet. Some conditions may require fasting, while in other cases, a certain type of food might need to be avoided.

❗ Seek immediate professional advice for:

- Difficulty in swallowing
- Severe pain
- Vomiting blood
- Blood in the stool

Important Note

For continuing or recurrent digestive problems, seek professional advice to determine the cause.

Stomachache

Cramping pain is a sign that the stomach and intestines are sore and irritated. This is normally due to poor digestion, excessive nervous tension, food poisoning, or infection. Stomachache may occur on its own or lead to vomiting and diarrhea (in which case, use the remedies on p. 306). Garlic and calendula are antiviral and will help clear digestive infections. Relaxing herbs, such as German chamomile and cramp bark, relieve stomach spasm. For maximum benefit, they are mixed with carminative herbs to help relieve gas.

❗ **General cautions** Seek professional advice if stomach pain is severe or recurrent. All species of mint (*Mentha* spp.) are unsuitable for children under 5.

Stomach Spasm

Relaxing herbs German chamomile (*Chamomilla recutita*, p. 77), lemon balm (*Melissa officinalis*, p. 113), cramp bark (*Viburnum opulus*, p. 150)

Carminative herbs Anise (*Pimpinella anisum*, p. 248), fennel (*Foeniculum vulgare*, p. 212), mint (*Mentha* spp., pp. 234–235), angelica (*Angelica archangelica*, p. 168)

Remedy Mix 3 parts of a relaxing herb to 1 part of a carminative herb and make an infusion. (For the carminative herbs, use fennel seeds, aniseed, mint leaves, or angelica root.) Drink up to 3 cups (750 ml) a day.

Digestive Infections

Herb Garlic (*Allium sativum*, p. 59)

Remedy Eat 1–2 fresh cloves a day.

Herb Calendula (*Calendula officinalis*, p. 73)

Remedy Infuse 2 tsp of herb in 3 cups (750 ml) of water and drink up to 3 cups a day.

Herbs Yarrow (*Achillea millefolium*, p. 56), peppermint (*Mentha x piperita*, p. 114), catnip (*Nepeta cataria*, p. 239)

Remedy Mix equal parts of each herb. Make an infusion of 2 tsp of mixture to ¾ cup (150 ml) of water. Drink 1¼ cups (300 ml) a day.

Caution Do not take yarrow in pregnancy.